

Hodges, the Supreme Court, citing the Fourteenth Amendment, obliged all states to perform and recognize same-sex marriages. At a stroke, gay marriage, with every legal right and obligation enjoyed by and conferred on heterosexual marriage, had become a fact of American life. It was a fundamental shift. In 1996, only 27 percent of Americans were in favor of same-sex marriage; in 2019, the figure was 61 percent.

Religious objections

While progressive attitudes to gay rights and same-sex marriage appeared to represent a new norm in the West, in reality, they were outliers. In 2005, Pope John-Paul II, an otherwise noted champion of human freedoms, claimed that homosexual marriages were part of “a new ideology of evil . . . insidiously threatening society.” “Homosexual acts,” he stated in 2000, “go against natural law.”

Catholic teaching found its most ready ally in the Muslim world. In 2019, Iran may have been extreme in still declaring homosexuality to be punishable by death, but in most Muslim countries, it remained illegal. The extent to which gay people were persecuted varied across the Islamic world, but the essential point was the same: homosexuality was a deviance from Sharia law. The persecutions of homosexuals in Chechnya from 2017 were not unrepresentative in presuming homosexuality to be a perversion.

Across much of Africa and Asia, homosexuality remained a more or less unmentionable subject. While it was decriminalized in China in

“ Marriage as a union of man and woman uniquely involving the procreating and rearing of children within the family is as old as the Book of Genesis.

Minnesota Supreme Court, 1971

1997, in India it was decriminalized only in 2018. In both cases, almost no other civil rights were extended to homosexuals. South Africa is the only African country to have made same-sex marriage legal (in 2006), while Taiwan is the only country in Asia to have done so (in 2019).

Trans rights

Since at least 2000, many in the West have also embraced a belief in transgender rights: that a person's biological gender is less important than their identification with either

gender. A biological male can identify as a female, and a biological female can identify as a male. This idea rests on the belief that societies too readily force boys and girls into predetermined gender-based roles, resulting in alienation and confusion for some individuals. But the concept left the rest of the world bemused, and some westerners thought it was pushing the liberated sexual agenda too far. Even some stalwart defenders of women's rights drew the line: in 2015, Germaine Greer, Australian intellectual and author of *The Female Eunuch*, said that in her opinion, transgender women were “not women.”

Human values

A core truth has remained. For all that the championing of nonheterosexual rights has been a near-exclusively Western concern, the principle that drove it was a defense of the values that inform humanity as a whole. Any human being has the right to be judged on their own terms. Sexuality can never be dismissed; it remains a fundamental of human existence. But it is no guide to the morality of any person. ■

Campaigners for same-sex marriage celebrated outside the US Supreme Court on June 26, 2015—the day it ruled that same-sex marriages were legal across the entire United States.

